Lesson 33: Grammar: Embedded Questions

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 9.4: Grammar Presentation-Embedded Questions; 9.5: Communication Practice.

In this lesson

You will learn to put a question inside a sentence (an embedded question) with statement word order, and to use it as a subject, an object, the object of a preposition or an adjective complement. You will find embedded questions in "What to Expect from Adolescence" (Lesson 32), complete and edit sentences, and use them in speaking and writing. Academic writers use them to state research questions: *Researchers want to know why teenagers take risks.*

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Change a direct question into an embedded question with statement word order.
- Use embedded questions as subjects, objects, objects of prepositions and adjective complements.
- Find and correct question word order inside a statement.
- Tell noun clauses, adjective clauses and adverb clauses apart when they begin with the same word.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
embedded question	a question inside a sentence; it uses statement word order	I don't know where my shoe is.
dependent clause	a group of words with a subject and a verb that cannot stand alone as a sentence	When they will arrive is unknown.
noun clause	a dependent clause that does the job of a noun (subject, object …)	What she studies is difficult.
statement word order	subject + verb, as in a normal statement	… where my shoe **is** (not ~~where is my shoe~~)
question word order	(question word +) auxiliary + subject + verb	What does she study?
auxiliary (helping) verb	a verb used with the main verb to make questions and tenses: do/does/did, be, have, will, can …	What **does** she study?
object of a preposition	the noun or clause after a preposition (about, of, in, on …)	I would like you to focus on where my shoe is.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
adjective complement	a clause after it + be + adjective that completes the adjective	It is unclear where my shoe is.
coming of age	becoming an adult; the celebration of it	… when their coming of age is celebrated depends on their culture.
speculate	to guess possible reasons without being sure	… some speculate that 16 gives adolescents freedom.

Rules and explanations

What an embedded question is

Embedded questions are noun clauses (dependent clauses). They use **statement word order**, not question word order. They can be the subject, a direct or indirect object, the object of a preposition or an adjective complement:

Function	Example (question: ***Where is my shoe?***)
subject	Where my shoe is will eventually be determined.
object	I don't know where my shoe is.
object of a preposition	I would like you to focus on where my shoe is.
adjective complement	It is unclear where my shoe is.

Patterns

	Pattern	Example
Question	Question word + auxiliary + subject + verb?	What does she study?
Embedded question: subject	[Question word + subject + verb] + verb	What she studies is difficult.
Embedded question: object	Subject + verb + [question word + subject + verb]	I wonder what she studies.
Embedded question: adjective complement	It + be + adjective + [question word + subject + verb]	It was obvious what she studies.

How to make an embedded question

1. **do / does / did:** remove it and put the tense on the main verb: *What does she study? → what she studies*.
2. **be, a modal (can, should …) or will:** put the subject before the verb: *Where is my shoe? → where my shoe is*.
3. **The question word is the subject:** the order does not change: *What will happen? → … you cannot choose what will happen*.

4. **Yes/no questions** use *if* or *whether* (Lesson 28): *Do you want a job? → He asked if I wanted a job.*
5. **The end punctuation** belongs to the whole sentence: a statement ends with a period (*I don't know where my shoe is.*); a question ends with a question mark (*Do you know where my shoe is?*).

Noun, adjective or adverb clause?

All three kinds of dependent clause can begin with the same word, for example *when* or *that*:

- **Noun clause** (subject or object): *When they will arrive is unknown.*
- **Adjective clause** (describes a noun): *The day when they arrived was hectic.*
- **Adverb clause** (tells when the main action happens): *When they arrive, we will begin.*

Knowing the difference helps your reading and your word order and punctuation in writing.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no helping verb like *do/does/did* in questions, so this English pattern is new. In an embedded question, remove *do/does/did* and put the tense on the main verb: *Where did he go? → I don't know where he went* (not ~~where did he go~~).

Practice

1. Embedded questions in the reading. These sentences are from "What to Expect from Adolescence". Underline each embedded question and say its function (subject, object, object of a preposition ...).

1. Unfortunately, no matter how you feel, you cannot choose when you will start to experience changes or what will happen. (Paragraph 1)
2. You begin to think more often about abstract ideas, such as love and beauty, rather than thinking just about what you can see and feel. (Paragraph 4)
3. If I asked you when you were seven years old what your favorite song was, you might respond with a song from the 80s or 90s. (Paragraph 5)
4. This is what people usually refer to when talking about "puberty." (Paragraph 6)
5. These are just a few examples of how much your body changes during this time period. (Paragraph 7)
6. Why you feel these things can seem like a mystery. (Paragraph 8)
7. In fact, it's always good to talk about what you're going through. (Paragraph 10)
8. You might feel like you don't recognize yourself and have no control over what's happening. (Paragraph 10)
9. The more people talk about these things, the more everyone will realize how normal it is. (Paragraph 10)

2. Exercise 3: Sentence completion. Choose the correct form.

1. I can't remember _____. a) which book did he want you to buy b) which book he wanted you to buy

2. They didn't tell me _____. a) why aren't your friends at home studying b) why didn't your friends at home studying c) why your friends aren't at home studying
3. Did he tell you _____? a) what did he find b) what he found c) what he finds
4. I know _____. a) how many states are there b) how many states there are
5. Guess _____! a) what did I buy b) what I buy c) what I bought
6. It's none of your business _____. a) how old am I b) how old I am
7. They were warned about _____. a) which neighbors should I avoid b) which neighbors I should avoid
8. The children are excited about _____. a) where they will go trick-or-treating b) where will they go trick-or-treating
9. My friend will be mad at his brother for _____. a) what did he say to their mother b) what he says to their mother c) what he said to their mother
10. I will ask her _____. a) where is the best sushi restaurant b) where the best sushi restaurant is
11. _____ depends on your preparation. a) How long it will take b) How long will it take
12. _____ seems obvious. a) How he can fix his relationship b) How can he fix his relationship
13. _____ is eleven days earlier every year. a) When do we celebrate Eid b) When we celebrate Eid
14. Do you know _____? a) what we will have for dinner b) what will we have for dinner
15. Can you tell me _____? a) where is the nearest restroom b) where the nearest restroom is
16. I don't care _____. a) which topic he chooses b) which topic does he choose c) which topic does he chooses

3. Exercise 4: Objects of prepositions. Make statements with the embedded question as the object of the preposition. Example: What languages does she speak at home? → I am interested in what languages she speaks at home.

1. Where will I see him? → I think about ...
2. Who is your teacher? → I was surprised about ...
3. Whose car was he driving? → I am unaware of ...
4. Why are they smiling? → I am interested in ...
5. Where are you in your career? → I am proud of ...

4. Exercise 5: Editing embedded questions. The paragraph about age ceremonies across cultures has eight embedded question errors. Find and correct them.

All children around the world eventually become adolescents; however, when is their coming of age celebrated depends on their culture. In the Jewish faith, 12 to 13-year-old boys and girls participate in a celebration called a Bar and Bat Mitzvah. Jewish historians offer many theories on how did this celebration began, but it rose in importance during the 18th and 19th centuries. In the Christian faith, 14-year-old boys and girls participate in the ritual of confirmation. Confirmation is what does signals the adolescent is a full member of society. A girl's 15th birthday is when do many Latin American

cultures celebrate a girl's passage to womanhood. However, various Latin American cultures differ in how do they celebrate the Quinceañera. Finally, the United States celebrates boys and girls at 16 years old ("sweet sixteen"). Why are adolescents celebrated at 16 in America is unknown, but some speculate that 16 gives adolescents freedom since they are allowed to get their driver's license. Becoming an adult means having the freedom to choose what do you want to do with life. However, these ceremonies mean taking new responsibilities. What do these ceremonies demonstrate is that becoming an adult is an entire community of friends, family, and neighbors.

5. Exercise 6: What do you know? Complete the sentences with embedded questions.

1. I don't know ...
2. I want to know ...
3. Do you know ...?
4. I wonder ...
5. Can you tell me ...?

Speak with your tutor

- "Exercise 7, I'm Not Sure: ask me five questions I may not know the answer to, like 'What is the capital of Alaska?' I will answer with an embedded question: 'I'm not sure what the capital of Alaska is.' Then I will ask you five."
- "Ask me ten direct questions about my studies. I will start each answer with 'I don't know ...', 'I wonder ...' or 'I can't remember ...'. Correct my word order."
- "Ask me about my adolescence. Make me use embedded questions, like 'What I remember most is ...' and 'I didn't understand why ...'."
- "Check my sentences for Exercise 6 and tell me the function of each embedded question."

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 120 to 180 words about your adolescence (discussion question 1 in Lesson 32: What was your adolescence like?).

- Use at least five embedded questions: at least one as a **subject** (*What I remember most is ...*), one as an **object** (*I did not understand why ...*), one as the **object of a preposition** (*I worried about what my friends thought*) and one as an **adjective complement** (*It was not clear what I wanted to study*).
- Use the simple past for your own teenage years.

Self-editing checklist:

1. Did I use at least five embedded questions in four different functions?
2. Does every embedded question have statement word order (subject before verb)?
3. Did I remove *do/does/did* and put the tense on the main verb?
4. Did I use *if* or *whether* for an embedded yes/no question?

5. Does each sentence end with the correct mark (a period for a statement, a question mark only if the whole sentence is a question)?
6. Did I use the simple past for past experiences?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Noun Clauses with Wh-Words: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1BEkdVMJZao
- Noun Clauses with if or whether: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zPoUhWvhHU8

Answer key

1. Embedded questions in the reading (book)

1. *when you will start to experience changes / what will happen*: object (of *choose*). (The book also marks *how you feel*, after *no matter*, as an object.)
2. *what you can see and feel*: object of a preposition (*about*).
3. *what your favorite song was*: object (of *asked*). (*When you were seven years old* is an adverb clause of time, not an embedded question.)
4. *what people usually refer to*: subject complement. (the book's key says object; this is a mistake because the clause comes after the verb *is*, and *be* has no object: a clause after *be* that tells what the subject (*This*) is, is called a subject complement)
5. *how much your body changes during this time period*: object of a preposition (*of*).
6. *Why you feel these things*: subject.
7. *what you're going through*: object of a preposition (*about*).
8. *what's happening*: object of a preposition (*over*).
9. *how normal it is*: object (of *realize*).

2. Exercise 3 (book): 1 b, 2 c, 3 b, 4 b, 5 c, 6 b, 7 b, 8 a, 9 c, 10 b, 11 a, 12 a, 13 b, 14 a, 15 b, 16 a. (Item 11: the book's key says b; this is a mistake because an embedded question uses statement word order: *How long it will take*.)

3. Exercise 4 (book)

1. I think about where I will see him.
2. I was surprised about who your teacher is.
3. I am unaware of whose car he was driving.
4. I am interested in why they are smiling.
5. I am proud of where you are in your career.

4. Exercise 5 (book)

1. when is their coming of age celebrated → when their coming of age is celebrated
2. how did this celebration began → how this celebration began
3. what does signals the adolescent → what signals that the adolescent (*that* is optional)
4. when do many Latin American cultures celebrate → when many Latin American cultures celebrate
5. how do they celebrate → how they celebrate
6. Why are adolescents celebrated → Why adolescents are celebrated
7. what do you want to do → what you want to do
8. What do these ceremonies demonstrate → What these ceremonies demonstrate

5. Exercise 6 (example answer)

1. I don't know why teenagers take so many risks.

2. I want to know how parents can help their teenagers.
3. Do you know when puberty usually begins?
4. I wonder whether my brain is still developing.
5. Can you tell me what a growth spurt is?

My notes